Noticing the Room

Civic Skill: Empathy | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 2 (Community) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will practise active, spontaneous noticing of others' emotional states in their immediate environment, and develop the habit of responding rather than walking past.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can notice when someone in our group seems to be feeling something.
- I can choose to check in, rather than walk past.
- I can ask 'are you okay?' or offer something without being prompted.

MATERIALS

- A 'kindness spotter' badge or sticker for each child (self-made is best)
- A simple observation journal — one page per child with a silhouette of a face
- Picture book: 'Have You Filled a Bucket Today?' by Carol McCloud
- Sticky notes in two colours

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. BOOK READ AND DISCUSS (7 min): Read 'Have You Filled a Bucket Today?' Focus on the idea of invisible buckets. 'What fills someone's bucket? What empties it?' Invite specific examples from the children's own experience.

2. KINDNESS SPOTTER CHALLENGE (3 min): Give each child a badge. 'For the next part of our session, you are a kindness spotter. Your job is to notice when someone needs their bucket filled — and do something about it. Don't wait to be asked.'

3. FREE PLAY / STRUCTURED ACTIVITY (10 min): Run a normal activity period while children wear their badges. Educator stays back, observes, and resists solving social moments — allow children to notice and respond.

4. DEBRIEF CIRCLE (7 min): On sticky notes (with adult scribing for non-writers): yellow = 'I noticed something' and blue = 'I did something.' Share notes. Focus on the gap: 'Did you notice something you didn't respond to? What stopped you?'

5. CLOSING: 'The hardest kindness is the one nobody else sees. But you see it. That's what a feelings detective knows.'

EXTENSIONS

- Keep the kindness spotter badge as a rotating role — a new child each day is 'on watch'
- Introduce a weekly 'bucket check' in the Monday circle — 'Whose bucket might need filling this week?'
- Write the class a shared letter: 'Things that fill our buckets in this room' — display and add to it

ASSESSMENT

- Note which children proactively approached others during free play without adult prompt
- Sticky note debrief is itself an assessment artefact — photograph and annotate
- Watch for children who noticed but didn't act — this is rich discussion material, not a failure

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Were there children whose buckets looked empty today? What could you do tomorrow?
- Did children notice peers they don't usually play with? What does that tell you about the social landscape of your room?
- How did it feel to step back and let children respond to each other? What made that hard?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) & Outcome 2 (Community). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.